ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

# Unreal past for diplomacy

Use past forms after would rather, it is time, suppose and polite frames to create distance from present reality. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use unreal past for diplomacy to express preference, criticism, suggestion or hypothetical distance with an appropriate interpersonal tone while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use past forms after would rather, it is time, suppose and polite frames to create distance from present reality.

MODEL

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

would rather + past | it is time + past | suppose + past

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

## LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main unreal past for diplomacy patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses express preference, criticism, suggestion or hypothetical distance with an appropriate interpersonal tone.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in negotiation, advice, formal conversation and tactful disagreement.

# Build meaning before form

Use past forms after would rather, it is time, suppose and polite frames to create distance from present reality.

# What unreal past for diplomacy communicates

Use past forms after would rather, it is time, suppose and polite frames to create distance from present reality.

The central purpose is to express preference, criticism, suggestion or hypothetical distance with an appropriate interpersonal tone. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

| I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. | a preference about another person's present or future action |
|---|---|
| It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. | a present action presented as overdue |
| Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? | a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion |

# How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: would rather + past | it is time + past | suppose + past. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model "I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change." shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

| Choice | Structure | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Present preference | would rather + different subject + past | I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. |
| Overdue action | it is time + subject + past | It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. |
| Hypothetical proposal | suppose/supposing + past | Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? |

# Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

| Meaning | Best route |
|---|---|
| a preference about another person’s present or future action | Present preference |
| a present action presented as overdue | Overdue action |
| a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion | Hypothetical proposal |

# Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in negotiation, advice, formal conversation and tactful disagreement. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

# Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 | 05 | 06 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| would rather | past | it is time | past | suppose | past |

## DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

### Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: express preference, criticism, suggestion or hypothetical distance with an appropriate interpersonal tone.

STEP 2

### Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

### Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

### Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits negotiation, advice, formal conversation and tactful disagreement.

STEP 5

### Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

# Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

| Pattern | Form | Model |
|---|---|---|
| Present preference | would rather + different subject + past | I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. |
| Overdue action | it is time + subject + past | It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. |
| Hypothetical proposal | suppose/supposing + past | Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? |

## EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

| | |
|---|---|
| I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. | a preference about another person's present or future action |
| It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. | a present action presented as overdue |
| Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? | a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion |

## COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

### Avoid this pattern

Do not use a present tense after would rather with a different subject in this unreal pattern.

EDIT THIS

### Avoid this pattern

Do not interpret the past form as past time here.

EDIT THIS

### Avoid this pattern

Do not combine the unreal past with a factual result clause.

# Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a preference about another person’s present or future action?

OPTIONS I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. · It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. · Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a present action presented as overdue?

OPTIONS It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. · Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? · I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion?

OPTIONS Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? · I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. · It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a preference about another person’s present or future action · a present action presented as overdue · a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a present action presented as overdue · a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion · a preference about another person’s present or future action

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion · a preference about another person’s present or future action · a present action presented as overdue

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Present preference / Overdue action / Hypothetical proposal · Gap 2: a preference about another person’s present or future action / a present action presented as overdue / a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Overdue action / Hypothetical proposal / Present preference · Gap 2: a present action presented as overdue / a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion / a preference about another person’s present or future action

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Hypothetical proposal / Present preference / Overdue action · Gap 2: a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion / a preference about another person’s present or future action / a present action presented as overdue

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

03 · PRACTICE STAGE

# Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a preference about another person’s present or future action: _____. Choose the model that expresses a present action presented as overdue: _____. Choose the model that expresses a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion: _____. Choose the model built with would rather + different subject + past: _____. Choose the model built with it is time + subject + past: _____. Choose the model built with suppose/supposing + past: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

## Available forms

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. · It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. · Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

I _____ the risks before approving the change. _____ the underlying cause. _____ at short notice: what would we do? State the full structural pattern for Present preference: _____. State the full structural pattern for Overdue action: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “My preference is for us to discuss the risks first.” using the Present preference pattern to express a preference about another person’s present or future action.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The organisation should address the cause now.” using the Overdue action pattern to express a present action presented as overdue.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Imagine that the supplier withdrew unexpectedly.” using the Hypothetical proposal pattern to express a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “My preference is for us to discuss the risks first.” using the Present preference pattern to express a preference about another person’s present or future action.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

### Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Present preference to express a preference about another person’s present or future action, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Overdue action to express a present action presented as overdue, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Hypothetical proposal to express a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

# Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

# Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

Present preference is the best match because a preference about another person’s present or future action.

A2

It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.

Overdue action is the best match because a present action presented as overdue.

A3

Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?

Hypothetical proposal is the best match because a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion.

A4

a preference about another person’s present or future action

The Present preference pattern communicates a preference about another person’s present or future action.

A5

a present action presented as overdue

The Overdue action pattern communicates a present action presented as overdue.

A6

a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion

The Hypothetical proposal pattern communicates a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion.

# Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

### Present preference / a preference about another person’s present or future action

The structure belongs to the Present preference pattern. Its communicative purpose is a preference about another person’s present or future action.

B2

### Overdue action / a present action presented as overdue

The structure belongs to the Overdue action pattern. Its communicative purpose is a present action presented as overdue.

B3

### Hypothetical proposal / a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion

The structure belongs to the Hypothetical proposal pattern. Its communicative purpose is a remote present or future scenario opened for discussion.

# Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

Present preference: would rather + different subject + past.

C2

It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.

Overdue action: it is time + subject + past.

C3

Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?

Hypothetical proposal: suppose/supposing + past.

C4

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

Present preference: would rather + different subject + past.

C5

It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.

Overdue action: it is time + subject + past.

C6

Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?

Hypothetical proposal: suppose/supposing + past.

# Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

would rather we discussed

Present preference requires “would rather we discussed” in this model. would rather + different subject + past.

D2

It is time the organisation addressed

Overdue action requires “It is time the organisation addressed” in this model. it is time + subject + past.

D3

Suppose the supplier withdrew

Hypothetical proposal requires “Suppose the supplier withdrew” in this model. suppose/supposing + past.

D4

would rather + different subject + past

Present preference is built as would rather + different subject + past.

D5

it is time + subject + past

Overdue action is built as it is time + subject + past.

# Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

would rather + different subject + past. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended present preference effect.

E2

It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause.

it is time + subject + past. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended overdue action effect.

E3

Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do?

suppose/supposing + past. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended hypothetical proposal effect.

E4

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change.

would rather + different subject + past. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended present preference effect.

# Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

I would rather we discussed the risks before approving the change. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses would rather + different subject + past accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

It is time the organisation addressed the underlying cause. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses it is time + subject + past accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

Suppose the supplier withdrew at short notice: what would we do? The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses suppose/supposing + past accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

# Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____